



Laying down the armour: Sreejesh's iconic goalkeeping kit — worn when he twisted with agility, dove with fearless precision, and at times stood immovable, like an impenetrable wall; each movement an attempt at defying the fiercest attempts of opposing goal-scorers. THULASI KAKKAT

identity.

"I had a photoshoot yesterday where I had to wear the kit, and I wanted to dry it out before packing it up," Sreejesh explained, swiftly quashing any speculation of a potential return to international hockey, just over a month after his retirement.

The drying goalkeeping kit provided the perfect segue into a nearly two-hour conversation.

"I distinctly remember the first time I wore a hockey kit. It was during the 2000 Ayudha Pooja. That's when everyone sets aside their equipment for the pooja, and that was the day I first tried it on," recalled Sreejesh, leaning back on his verandah's sit-out, easing into the conversation.

"When I was in the eighth grade, my father bought me my first personal goalkeeping kit. It wasn't international standard, just enough

for state-level play," he added.

A hockey ball weighs just over 150 grammes, but anyone who's been hit by one would swear it feels much heavier. Now imagine that ball coming at you at nearly 100 kmph from different angles and heights! Scary. Overcoming the fear of pain is therefore crucial for a hockey goalkeeper to gain a foothold in the sport. And that process is closely tied to the trust placed in the armour — the goalkeeping kit.

"It wasn't until 2004, when I joined the junior Indian team, that I wore a

proper kit. A better kit not only reduces impact and pain but also improves rebounds. A lot of our confidence comes from the quality of our equipment. It's like the difference between wearing Rs. 100 canvas shoes and Rs. 10,000 Nike shoes. Both are shoes, but the perception and conviction change," explained Sreejesh.

A goalkeeper, across various ball sports, is an antithesis to the discipline itself. His role is to negate the very essence of the game — scoring a goal. But in modern Indian hockey, Sreejesh flipped this narrative. His stellar performances in goal became the foundation upon which Indian hockey experienced its revival.

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